

Step 3 · The prototype

Three hours, hard stop. Twenty points, and the only row a reader experiences rather than reads. The bar is not polish: one flow, end to end, real enough that somebody can attempt the task while you sit there in silence.

WHERE THIS GETS YOU · STEP 3 OF 3



When this is done you hold: a link that opens for a stranger, one flow that runs end to end, five states, a session log with a number in it, and judgement line 3 of 3. **Banked: Prototype 20, and Judgement 15 has its three lines. The capstone exists at this point** — C.5 is packaging what you already have.

THE HARD STOP

Three hours, or one flow working, whichever comes first

Capstones die here, of scope, not of skill. Put a timer where you can see it.

THE GATE

The In list from C.3

Do not open the build tool without it. Ten minutes of cutting saves an hour of building the wrong thing.

FROM 4.2

One tool, one person

Use it → Lovable. See it → v0. Plus one human who will click it.

FOR ROWAN

A state, then a task

"You have not opened this in three weeks. Show me what you would do." Then silence.

THE FOUR MOVES

1 The build brief, four layers 25 MIN · BEFORE YOU TYPE INTO THE TOOL

1 Who + the job — "an ops coordinator at a 120-person company needs a 30-minute slot with four colleagues this week." **2 One screen, one flow. 3 Fake data, specified** — six named people, real-looking availability, two with no overlap on purpose. Unspecified fake data gives you three users called John Doe and a demo that proves nothing. **4 The fence**, the tallest layer:

LAYER 4 · PASTE VERBATIM

Build only this screen and this flow. No landing page, no pricing page, no settings, no sign-up, no navigation to anything that does not exist. If something is out of scope, leave the button out entirely rather than adding a placeholder.

2 The loop, and the stop rule 90 MIN

LOOK → DECIDE (one thing wrong that matters) → ONE CHANGE (describe the outcome, not the code) → LOOK. One change per turn; two and you cannot tell which caused what. **Three attempts at the same problem, then stop asking and rewrite from scratch** — attempt four is where sessions die. Do not read the code: it is a drawing that happens to run, and anything a real customer would touch goes to engineers.

3 The five states 30 MIN · CHEAPEST POINTS IN THE CAPSTONE

PASTE THIS

For this screen, show me all five states: **default** (populated as specified), **empty**, **loading**, **error**, and **overflow** (a 40-character name, and 12 items where I designed for 4). Do not change the layout between states.

Then look at overflow properly. A long name breaking the layout is the first thing a real person will do to your demo, and it is what makes a good flow look like a toy.

4 One person, in silence 35 MIN

One task, one sentence, said once: "You need a thirty minute slot with these four people this week. Go." Then **you do not talk** — not to explain the button, not to apologise for placeholder text. What they **did** is data; what they **said** is politeness. Watch the stall, the double click, the back-out, the wrong entry point.

Log it in the table below, while it is fresh. One line of that — **"4 of 6 found the send button"** — outranks a page describing the interface.

SELF-CHECK · PROTOTYPE, 20 PTS

- ☐ One flow runs **end to end without you narrating**
- ☐ Fake data specified and plausible, including one case that fails on purpose
- ☐ Five states exist on the screen that matters
- ☐ No dead buttons, no links to screens that do not exist
- ☐ **One person attempted the task in silence**, and you wrote down what they did
- ☐ Link opens for a stranger: **private window, signed out, on a phone**

THE FASTEST FAIL

Six half-working screens, a landing page, and no task anyone can attempt. The share-default check is second: one setting has killed more capstones than any design flaw.

STEP 3 · JUDGEMENT LINE

What the AI got wrong here, and what I did about it:

THE SESSION LOG · WRITE IT WHILE IT IS FRESH · THIS IS SLOT 4 OF YOUR ONE-PAGER

WHAT I ASKED	WHAT THEY DID · STALLS AND DETOURS, IN ORDER, WITH ROUGH TIMINGS	WHAT I CHANGED